

Has your design recommendation ever been **overruled**?

Because someone more senior had a different opinion.

That pattern has a name:

the **HiPPO effect** (McAfee & Brynjolfsson, 2012).



Fifteen professionals. Zero systematic frameworks.

Across fifteen expert interviews: UX designers, technical leads, quality engineers, project managers, not one described a systematic process for choosing an interface type.

"Decisions here are not grounded in evidence. It is much more authoritarian than evidence-based."

UX/Digital Designer
15 yrs experience

"Basically, what prevents me from presenting a structured proposal to the client is the client themselves."

Delivery Project Manager
8 yrs experience

"You grab the template you like the most. There is no way to say which interface type suits the project better."

Senior Fullstack Developer
10 yrs experience

— THE GAP

Good tools for **how** to design. Nothing for **what** to design.

Every design methodology assumes you have already chosen what kind of interface to build.

None of them help you make that choice.

Refining a chosen interface

Improving it, fitting it to users, testing and iterating

Exists

Choosing the interface type

Screen · voice · wearable · AI · spatial: which one?

Missing

Right technology. Wrong interface type.



Google Glass
2013

VALUES MISMATCH

Rejected on privacy, not technology.



Humane AI Pin
2024

LATENCY + REDUNDANCY

5 to 10 second response delays.



Rabbit R1
2024

VALUE PROPOSITION

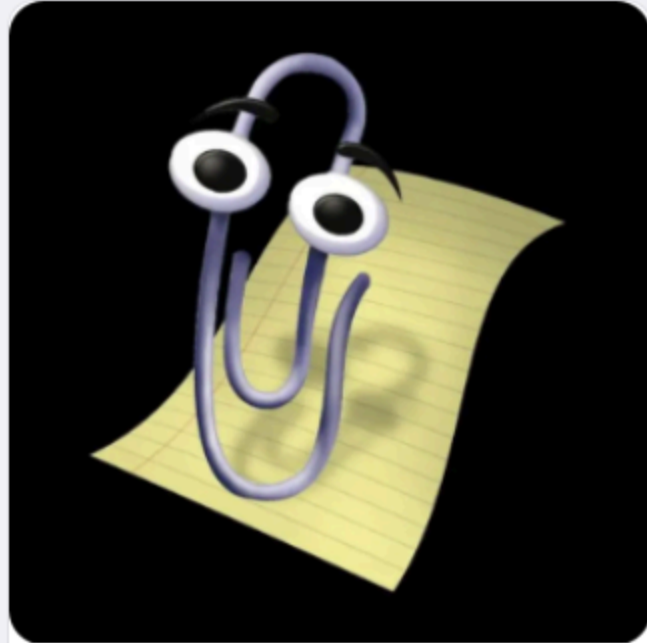
"Why not just use my phone?"



Fire Phone
2014

TASK MISMATCH

\$170M writedown. No task required.



Clippy
2001

INTERACTION INITIATION

Interrupted users. They demanded removal.

Millions in combined documented losses across just five cases. Only the numbers companies disclosed.

— IT IS NOT AN ISOLATED PATTERN

The failure is not technical. It is structural.

95%

of generative AI pilots fail to deliver measurable impact.

MIT NANDA • 2025

80%

of AI projects never reach real use, twice conventional IT.

RAND Corporation • 2024

84%

of those failures trace to leadership decisions, not engineering.

RAND Corporation • 2024

The bottleneck is the decision. Not the technology.

Master's Thesis Defense · 2026

• BEYOND INTUITION:

A Designer's Framework for Interface Type Selection

Author

ZARATE Ilverzon

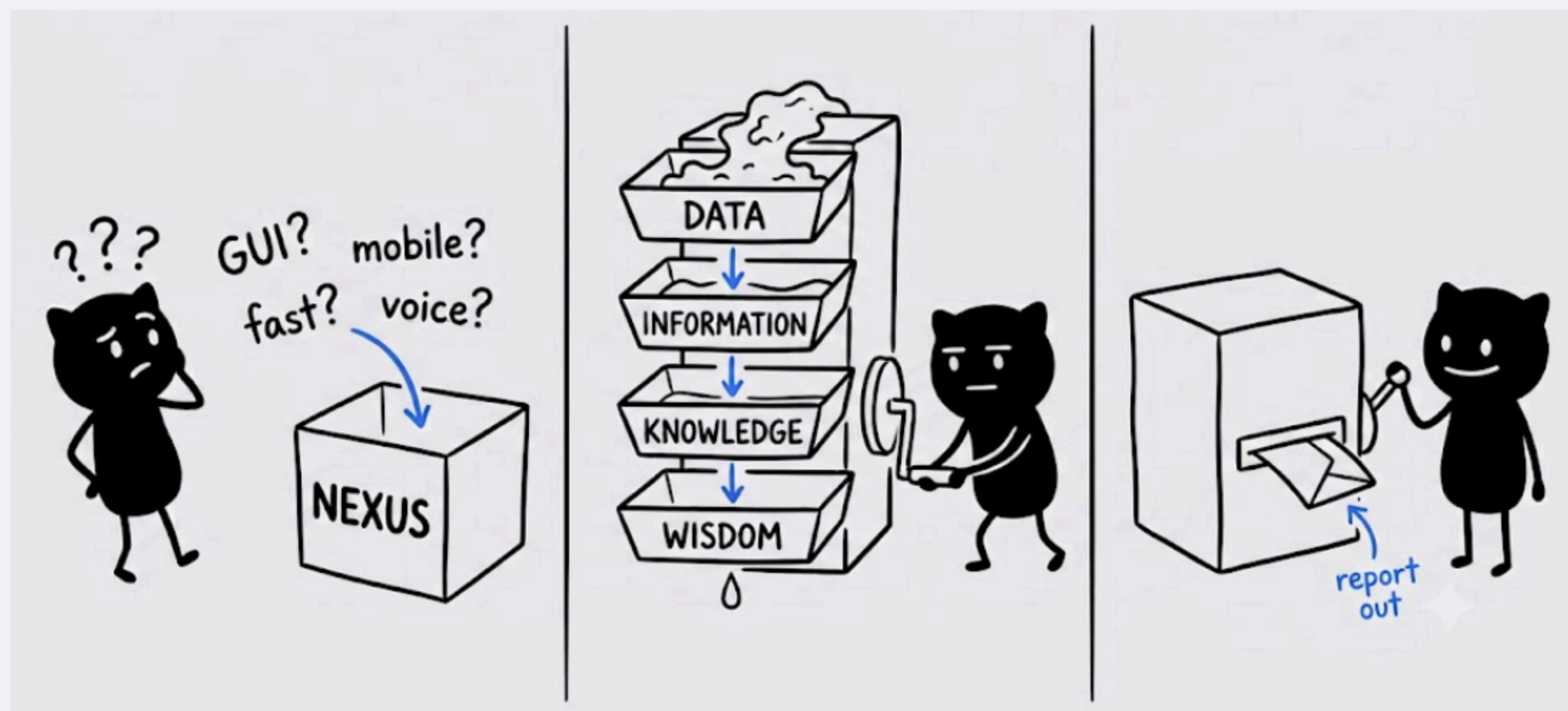
Director

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Master in Advanced Studies in Design - Barcelona (UPC / UB)

Give it a decision. Get back **evidence**.



Your decision

NEXUS

A structured report

A structured conversation, in four stages.

The decision that happens before the first mockup.
Made explicit, documented, and defensible.

CORE PRINCIPLE

Values come first.
Before any technical question.

01 —

Values

Rank what the organisation stands for. That ranking is the primary filter.

02 —

Context

Fifteen questions: users, frequency, environment, consequence of failure.

03 —

Patterns

Does this resemble any of the five documented failures? The framework flags it.

04 —

Report

Not a verdict. Alignments, tensions, precedents. You read it. You decide.

15 questions, four DIKW layers.

Each question maps to a layer of the DIKW hierarchy established by Ackoff in 1989. The framework cannot be short-circuited: values are always evaluated before any technical question.

WISDOM Values ranking What does your organisation actually stand for? Primary filter. Evaluated before any technical question.	KNOWLEDGE Context factors Task complexity, frequency, predictability, context of use, information type. Who are the users and how do they work?	INFORMATION Risk factors Error consequence, control preference, user demographics, exploration mode. What happens if something goes wrong?	DATA Constraints Product type, existing solutions, interaction initiation, geography. Hard limits that constrain viable interface types.
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Three phases. Three kinds of evidence.

PHASE 01

CONSTRUCTION

Built from the literature

Literature confirmed the gap. Interviews built the values taxonomy.

15 practitioners interviewed
UX designers • technical
leads • quality engineers
• project managers

PHASE 02

RETROSPECTIVE

Tested against history

Applied to five failures, pre-launch information only.

5 cases
pre-launch data only

PHASE 03

PROOF OF CONCEPT

Validated with practitioners

Built and validated with the same fifteen practitioners.

15 participants
tool session

Did it see what went wrong?

82%

of documented failure factors identified across all five cases.
Target 70 % • Landis & Koch (1977)

70%

agreement with designer
judgment

4.3/5

ease of use • 12 of 15 rated 4 or
5

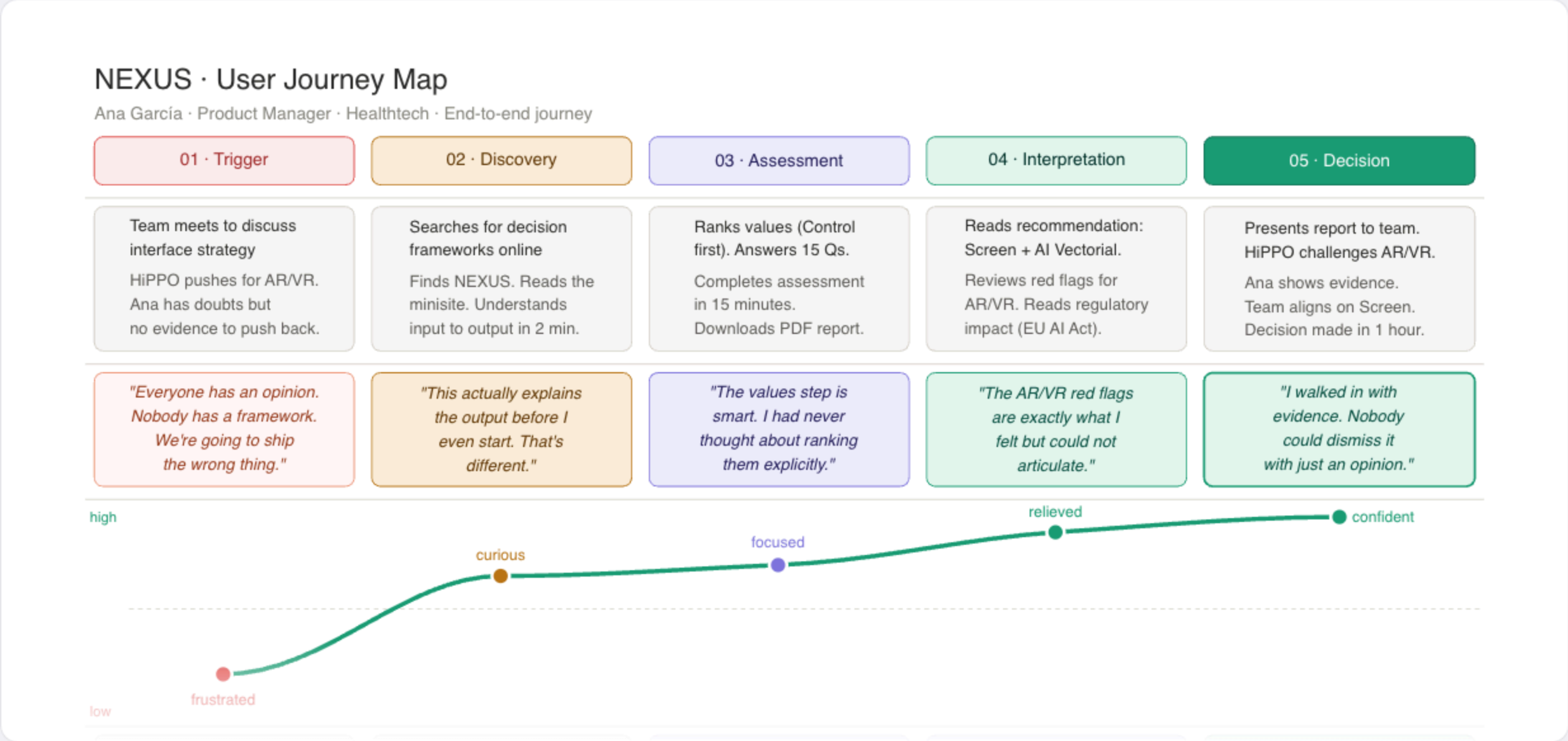
Applied to each product using only pre-launch public information.

PRODUCT	WHAT WENT WRONG	CAUGHT?
Google Glass	Privacy violation in public spaces	Yes
Humane AI Pin	Privacy + tech not ready for context	Yes
Rabbit R1	Problem users had already solved	Yes
Fire Phone	Innovation mismatched with phone use	Yes
Clippy	Automation that removed user control	Yes

From HiPPO pressure to evidence-backed decision.

Ana, a product manager in healthtech, walks into a meeting where AR/VR is being pushed without evidence. This is what happens next.

Emotion goes from frustrated to confident. The HiPPO is still in the room. But now so is the evidence.



NEXUS in the browser.

Live demo.

Fifteen minutes, no installation.

A guided conversation about values, context, and constraints.

Ending in a report, not an answer.

- nexus-flame-delta.vercel.app/demo

INPUT

Rank five values.

Control · accessibility ·
sustainability · efficiency · joy.

THEN

Answer 15 context questions.

Users · frequency · environment ·
consequence of failure.

OUTPUT

A structured report.

Type alignment · tensions · relevant
historical precedents.

POSITION

It informs. You decide.

Four contributions. One open platform.

FOR THE FIELD

A replicable method

First application of DIKW to interface type selection. Extensible to new types, contexts, and failures not yet documented.

FOR PRACTICE

Evidence to defend good decisions

A structured argument for designers. Makes judgment visible, documented, and harder to override by opinion alone, including the HiPPO's.

FOR THE COMMUNITY

Infrastructure that outlives the defense

MIT-licensed. Open to all. The research does not end here.

AS A POSITION

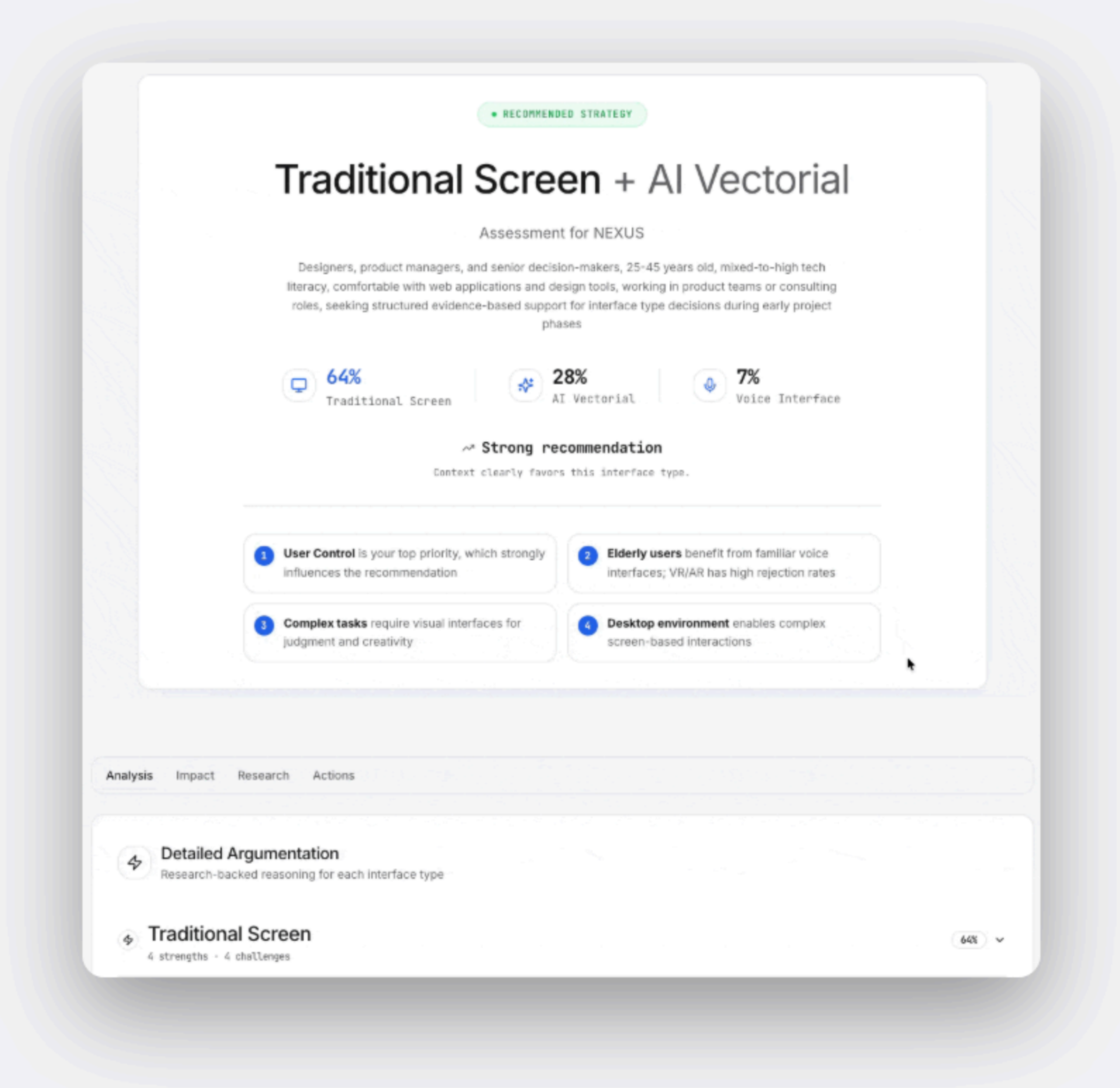
"It informs. It does not decide."

Structure in service of human judgment, not instead of it.



Under a minute.
Everything you just heard, in motion.

Thank
you.



Why DIKW and not Cynefin, AHP, or TAM?

Requirement	Design Thinking	TAM	MCDA	DIKW
Operates before type selection	No	No	Partial	Yes
Accommodates values without quantification	Yes	No	No	Yes
Enables cross-type comparison	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Incorporates documented failure patterns	No	No	No	Yes
Accessible to non-specialist practitioners	Yes	No	No	Yes

Why these five cases and not others?

01

Commercial impact

Min. €100M investment or significant market withdrawal.

02

Documentation quality

Multiple independent sources: press, company comms, academic papers, user feedback.

03

Temporal coverage

1997–2024 across five interface types: automation, spatial, AI, screen, voice.

04

Interface type diversity

One case per category. Prevents skew from repeated failures in one type.

Are the patterns actually generalizable?

Recurrent across the corpus, not universal. That distinction matters.

WHAT THE CORPUS SUPPORTS

Five cases, 27 years, five interface types. All failures traceable to the same six pattern categories. Sufficient to structure a pre-selection checklist.

WHAT IT DOES NOT CLAIM

All cases are Western and high-budget. Other contexts may surface different patterns. The framework is designed to expand through community contribution.

It structures the questions that make failure less invisible.

How does the scoring algorithm work?

01

Values filter first

Types contradicting top-ranked values are flagged before scoring. Hard filter, not a weight.

02

Context scoring

15 questions map to each type's strengths. Responses generate a compatibility profile per type.

03

Pattern matching

Failure triggers activate red flags with severity: blocking, critical, or warning.

04

Report generation

Alignments and tensions, not scores. The designer sees the reasoning, not just the result.

What if two interface types score the same?

A tie is not a failure. It is information.

WHAT IT MEANS

The context doesn't strongly favour either type. Both are viable given current inputs.

WHAT THE REPORT SHOWS

Both types side by side: red flags and alignments compared directly.
Tension profiles, not scores.

WHAT THE DESIGNER DOES

Decides based on specific risks. The "informs, not decides" principle in practice.

How does NEXUS evolve after this defense?

Year 1 — **Single maintainer**

Author maintains quality. Community PRs accepted via structured review.

Year 2 — **Community steering**

Contributor council governs. Domain-specific forks enabled.

Year 3 — **Distributed ownership**

Full community control. Plugin architecture for swappable AI providers.

MIT license means anyone can use, modify, and extend it. No permission required, no payment needed.

Is this a master's thesis or a doctoral dissertation?

Deliberately bounded. One primary contribution, three subordinate.

PRIMARY — METHODOLOGICAL

Replicable retrospective validation and values-first filtering.
The field can build on this independently of the platform.

SUBORDINATE CONTRIBUTIONS

Theoretical: first DIKW application. Practical: NEXUS as
proof of concept. Infrastructural: open-source governance
model.

Field validation across organizations is the explicit next step, it is not a gap in this work.

Input to output. Every step transparent.

From values ranking through scoring to recommendation. Each layer builds on the previous. The designer sees the reasoning behind every flag.

- Interface types and outputs
- Assessment factors (15 questions)
- Decision logic and red flag detection
- Processing nodes

